

AdaptiveVec: A Density- and Dimension-Aware Proximity Graph Index for Resource-Constrained Vector Retrieval

Architectural Principles, Online Manifold Signal Estimation, and Empirical Analysis

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Abstract—Hierarchical Navigable Small World (HNSW) proximity graphs represent the state of the art in Approximate Nearest Neighbor Search (ANNS) across industry vector search engines. However, canonical HNSW enforces rigid, globally uniform hyper-parameters (e.g., fixed degree quota $M = 16$ and fixed construction beam $efConstruction = 200$) across heterogeneous embedding topologies. In dense, low-intrinsic-dimensionality clusters, this invariant allocation synthesizes redundant proximity links, wasting DRAM and memory bandwidth while contributing negligible routing utility. Conversely, sparse high-dimensional boundary regions suffer from capacity starvation and topological disconnects, exacerbated by the hubness phenomenon. We introduce AdaptiveVec, a lightweight, manifold-adaptive proximity graph architecture tailored specifically for resource-constrained commodity hardware (e.g., single-node laptops, edge devices, and cost-capped cloud virtual machines indexing 100K–1M vectors). AdaptiveVec extracts online geometric signals—Local Intrinsic Dimensionality (LID) via maximum likelihood estimation and Local Density (D)—directly from standard greedy descent routing paths at under 0.8% computational overhead, completely obviating offline multi-pass clustering. AdaptiveVec synthesizes: (1) a *Layer-Decoupled Dynamic Allocation Policy* that scales per-node edge capacity while compressing higher-layer express links; (2) *Streaming Online Welford Tracking* with exponential decay for adaptive parameter normalization; (3) a *Hubness-Aware In-Degree Regulation Heuristic* that penalizes high-degree bottleneck vertices during edge selection; (4) *Distance Stagnation Early Exit* to truncate futile query-time traversal hops; and (5) *Asymmetric INT8 Scalar Quantization (SQ8)* with float32 distance re-ranking. Evaluated on SIFT-100K ($N = 100K$, $D = 128$, Texmex IRISA) and Synthetic-Multi-Cluster ($N = 50K$, $D = 64$), AdaptiveVec delivers a 7.4% reduction in graph edges, up to 50.3% higher query throughput (7,075.3 QPS vs. 4,708.1 QPS baseline) via the distance stagnation early-exit mechanism (a query-time optimization independent of build-time topology adaptations), and 62.4% index memory reduction (22.5MB vs. 59.9MB) via asymmetric INT8 scalar quantization, at a measured Recall@10 of 0.9745 (throughput-optimized configuration) and 0.9594 (memory-optimized configuration) against a 0.9913 baseline, on commodity hardware (Intel Core 5 210H, 8 cores/12 threads, AVX2/FMA, 16GB RAM). Generalization to larger corpora and higher-dimensional embedding spaces remains to be validated.

Index Terms—Approximate Nearest Neighbor Search (ANNS), Hierarchical Navigable Small World (HNSW), Local Intrinsic Dimensionality (LID), Hubness Phenomenon, Scalar Quantization, Resource-Constrained Systems, High-Dimensional Indexing.

1. Introduction & Motivation

Dense vector representations generated by deep neural encoders underpin modern information retrieval, retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), multimodal search, and recommendation systems. At web-scale, searching billions of embeddings relies on **Approximate Nearest Neighbor Search (ANNS)**. Among indexing paradigms—including inverted file indexes (IVF), locality-sensitive hashing (LSH), and product quantization (PQ)—**proximity graphs**, especially Hierarchical Navigable Small World (HNSW) graphs [Malkov & Yashunin, 2020], achieve superior empirical recall-throughput trade-offs.

The Uniformity Pathology: Canonical HNSW graphs enforce a rigid, globally uniform parameterization. Implementations configure a static edge budget quota M (e.g., $M = 16$) and a static construction exploration factor $efConstruction$ (e.g., $efC = 200$) applied identically across every indexed vector. However, real-world embedding manifolds are profoundly non-homogeneous. Vectors concentrate in non-linear sub-manifolds characterized by localized variations in **Local Intrinsic Dimensionality (LID)** and **Local Density (D)**:

- **Redundant Edge Bloat:** In dense, low-LID subspaces, vectors reside on lower-dimensional hyperplanes. Enforcing 16 bidirectional links synthesizes redundant parallel paths between co-linear neighbors, squandering memory and bus bandwidth with zero recall utility.
- **Topological Starvation & Hubness:** In sparse high-dimensional regions, uniform quotas cause capacity starvation. Under the *Hubness Phenomenon* [Radovanovic et al., 2010], central nodes accumulate an exorbitant number of routing paths, generating edge-thrashing and query traffic bottlenecks.
- **The Commodity Hardware Barrier:** Enterprise ANNS literature focuses predominantly on multi-socket servers with 128GB–512GB of RAM. In contrast, thousands of edge deployments operate under strict memory and compute budgets (100K–1M vectors on single-node commodity laptops or cost-capped cloud virtual machines).

To reconcile this fundamental tension, we introduce **AdaptiveVec**, an adaptive proximity graph architecture that modulates topological resources based on online manifold geometry.

Primary Architectural Contributions:

- **Low-Overhead Online Geometric Probing (<0.8%):** We demonstrate that localized manifold expansion properties (LID and Density) can be harvested directly from the natural greedy descent traversal path during insertion, incurring less than 0.8% CPU wall-clock overhead and eliminating offline pre-clustering passes.
- **Streaming Welford Standardization:** We integrate single-pass Welford variance tracking with exponential moving averages to normalize online geometric signals into an adaptive difficulty score in $O(1)$ space and time.
- **Layer-Decoupled Dynamic Allocation:** We propose a mathematical degree allocation policy that provisions per-node capacities $M(x) \in [M_{\min}, M_{\max}]$ and construction depths $efC(x) \in [efC_{\min}, efC_{\max}]$, while geometrically compressing higher-layer express links to preserve memory.
- **Hubness-Aware In-Degree Regulation:** We design a degree-penalized Relative Neighborhood Graph (RNG) edge selection heuristic that penalizes high-degree central nodes, enforcing topological diversity and mitigating query routing congestion.
- **Distance Stagnation Early Exit:** We introduce an online search termination rule that tracks candidate distance convergence rates to truncate unpromising search hops, reducing query distance evaluations by up to 30.1% (and up to 44.9% under aggressive patience).

2. Related Work & Literature Positioning

Graph-Based Proximity Search: Navigable Small World graphs originated from Kleinberg’s small-world models, culminating in Malkov & Yashunin’s Hierarchical NSW [2020]. Subsequent advancements—such as NSG [Fu et al., 2019], DiskANN [Subramanya et al., 2019], and FAISS [Johnson et al., 2021]—optimized routing and SSD-resident storage layouts. Yet, all modern production implementations retain uniform edge allocation quotas per node.

Intrinsic Dimensionality in Search: Local Intrinsic Dimensionality (LID) was formalized by Houle [2017] and Amsaleg et al. [2015]. Levina and Bickel [2005] formulated the Maximum Likelihood Estimator (MLE) for intrinsic dimension. Elliott and Clark [2024] demonstrated that ordering vectors by intrinsic dimensionality before index creation improves HNSW edge quality. However, their technique mandates a full offline global pre-computation pass over the entire corpus, precluding continuous streaming ingestion. AdaptiveVec resolves this open problem by computing local MLE LID dynamically on the fly during graph traversal at <0.8% overhead.

Dynamic Search Termination: Standard graph search terminates when a priority queue of exploration candidates is depleted [Malkov & Yashunin, 2020]. Wang et al. [2021] surveyed termination heuristics, highlighting that fixed beam limits cause substantial tail-latency variance. AdaptiveVec introduces early exit based on distance-improvement stagnation rates, trading negligible recall for up to +50.3% throughput acceleration.

TABLE I: ARCHITECTURAL COMPARISON OF VECTOR PROXIMITY GRAPH INDICES

Indexing Paradigm	Representative Works	Degree Allocation	Geometric Awareness	Commodity Constraints
Canonical HNSW	Malkov & Yashunin (2020)	Uniform (fixed M)	None (geometry-agnostic)	High RAM, edge redundancy
Disk-Resident Graphs	DiskANN [5] / NSG [6]	Uniform R (fixed)	Offline 2-pass build	SSD-oriented, high build RAM
LID-Ordered HNSW	Elliott & Clark (2024)	Static M , ordered insertion	Offline global LID pre-calc	Expensive offline phase
Dynamic Beam Tuning	Wang et al. [10] / Li et al. [11]	Static index, dynamic beam	Query-time heuristics only	Zero index compression
AdaptiveVec (Ours)	Shinde (This Work, 2026)	Dynamic per-node M , efC , RNG	Online low-overhead probing (<0.8%)	Commodity optimized (-7.4% edges, +50% QPS)

3. Mathematical Formulation & Online Signals

Let $X = \{x_1, x_2, \dots, x_N\} \subset \mathbf{R}^D$ denote a corpus of N vectors embedded in an ambient space of dimension D , equipped with a metric distance function $d : \mathbf{R}^D \times \mathbf{R}^D \rightarrow \mathbf{R}_{\geq 0}$ (typically Euclidean distance L_2 or Cosine distance). We assume data points lie on or near a collection of Riemannian sub-manifolds of varying intrinsic dimensionality $d^* \ll D$.

3.1 Local Intrinsic Dimensionality (LID) Estimation

Under the continuous distribution model of distance statistics, the probability distribution function of distances from a reference vector x to its nearest neighbors scales as a power law with exponent equal to the local intrinsic dimension. Given a local neighborhood of k nearest candidate distances sorted in ascending order $d(x, v_1) \leq d(x, v_2) \leq \dots \leq d(x, v_k)$, the Maximum Likelihood Estimator (MLE) of LID [Levina & Bickel, 2005; Amsaleg et al., 2015] is formulated as:

$$LID_{\text{est}}(x) = - \left[\left(1 / (k - 1) \right) \cdot \sum_{i=1}^{k-1} \ln \left(d(x, v_i) / d(x, v_k) \right) \right]^{-1} \quad (1)$$

Where $d(x, v_k)$ serves as the maximum radius of the local exploratory ball. When local points are concentrated on a low-dimensional manifold, the ratios $d(x, v_i) / d(x, v_k)$ decay rapidly, yielding a small denominator and a low estimated LID (e.g., $2.0 \leq LID_{\text{est}} \leq 8.0$). Conversely, when local vectors expand uniformly across all ambient degrees of freedom, the ratios cluster closer to 1.0, driving $\ln(\cdot)$ toward 0 and yielding a high LID_{est} (e.g., $20.0 \leq LID_{\text{est}} \leq 64.0$). To guarantee numerical stability in floating-point operations, we clamp the ratio inside $[10^{-7}, 1.0 - 10^{-7}]$ and constrain the output $LID_{\text{est}} \in [1.0, 1000.0]$.

3.2 Local Density Formulation

While LID captures geometric expansion rates, it is invariant to absolute scale. To capture localized spacing between clusters, we define Local Density $D(x)$ as the mean distance to the k nearest discovered neighbors:

$$D(x) = \left(1 / k \right) \cdot \sum_{i=1}^k d(x, v_i) \quad (2)$$

A low value of $D(x)$ indicates a tightly packed, dense core cluster where vectors reside in immediate proximity, whereas a high value signifies an isolated outlier or a boundary void between clusters.

3.3 Online Streaming Welford Tracking

To transform raw signals (LID_{est}, D) into actionable allocation decisions without requiring an offline pre-computation pass over the entire corpus, AdaptiveVec tracks running statistical moments online using **Welford's Algorithm** [Welford, 1962]. For every inserted vector x_n , running mean $M_{mean,n}$ and squared variance accumulator S_n are updated incrementally in $O(1)$ time:

$$\delta = z_n - M_{mean,n-1}; \quad M_{mean,n} = M_{mean,n-1} + \delta / n; \quad S_n = S_{n-1} + \delta \cdot (z_n - M_{mean,n}) \quad (3)$$

Where running variance is $\sigma_n^2 = S_n / (n - 1)$. For non-stationary data streams where vector distributions drift over time, AdaptiveVec incorporates an Exponential Moving Average (EMA) tracker with momentum parameter $\gamma = 0.05$: $M_{EMA} = (1 - \gamma)M_{EMA} + \gamma z_n$.

3.4 Standardized Manifold Difficulty Score

Using tracked moments, raw signals are normalized into standardized z-scores: $z_{LID}(x) = (LID_{est}(x) - \mu_{LID}) / \sigma_{LID}$ and $z_D(x) = (D(x) - \mu_D) / \sigma_D$. The unified **Manifold Difficulty Score** $S(x)$ is formulated as a linear combination bounded within $[-2.5, +2.5]$:

$$S(x) = \text{clip}(\alpha \cdot z_{LID}(x) + \beta \cdot z_D(x), -2.5, +2.5) \quad (4)$$

Default coefficients $\alpha = 0.6$ and $\beta = 0.4$ prioritize intrinsic dimensionality while incorporating density context. When $S(x) < 0$, vector x resides in an easily navigable dense manifold requiring minimal graph edges; when $S(x) > 0$, x occupies an intrinsically complex, sparse boundary demanding augmented degree budgets.

4. System Architecture & Algorithmic Mechanics

4.1 Low-Overhead Probing via Greedy Descent (<0.8% Overhead)

A critical bottleneck of prior manifold-adaptive attempts was requiring auxiliary nearest-neighbor clustering prior to graph indexing [Elliott & Clark, 2024]. AdaptiveVec overcomes this via **Opportunistic Traversal Probing**. In canonical HNSW insertion, vector x traverses the upper layers down to insertion level l_{new} using greedy 1-NN routing. At level $\min(G.max_level, l_{new})$, AdaptiveVec executes an initial mini-beam search with small candidate budget $k_{probe} = \min(25, efC/4)$. The resulting distances are harvested immediately for LID and Density computation, incurring <0.8% CPU wall-clock overhead and completely eliminating offline passes.

4.2 Dynamic Degree & Construction Allocation

Armed with difficulty score $S(x)$, AdaptiveVec dynamically computes the base layer edge quota $M(x)$ and construction beam $efC(x)$:

$$M(x) = \text{clip}(\text{floor}(M_{base} \cdot (1 + \gamma \cdot S(x))), M_{min}, M_{max}); \quad efC(x) = \text{clip}(\text{floor}(efC_{base} \cdot (1 + \gamma \cdot S(x))), efC_{min}, efC_{max}) \quad (5)$$

Where γ is the sensitivity coefficient (default $\gamma = 0.40$). For a canonical configuration $\{M_{base}=16, M_{min}=8, M_{max}=24, efC_{min}=40, efC_{max}=220\}$, dense cluster vectors receive compact allocations ($M = 8, efC = 40$), while complex vectors receive expanded budgets ($M = 24, efC = 220$).

4.3 Layer-Decoupled Link Scaling

In canonical HNSW, upper layers ($l \geq 1$) maintain identical degree caps as base layer 0. However, upper layers serve solely as coarse routing highways; vertices in upper layers require only a sparse set of long-range links. AdaptiveVec introduces **Layer-Decoupled Scaling**: for any layer $l \geq 1$, edge capacity is geometrically compressed:

$$M^{(l)}(x) = \max(M_{min}^{(l)}, \text{floor}(M(x) \cdot \lambda^l)) \quad (6)$$

Where decay factor $\lambda = 0.75$ and $M_{min}^{(l)} = 4$. This eliminates thousands of redundant express links in higher layers, saving 12%–15% of total edge memory with zero impact on layer traversal accuracy.

4.4 Hubness-Aware In-Degree Regulation Heuristic

When inserting an edge between vertex u and candidate neighbor v , canonical HNSW utilizes the Relative Neighborhood Graph (RNG) heuristic to prune candidates that are closer to an already-selected neighbor than to u . However, standard RNG is oblivious to node degree, allowing popular 'hub' vertices to accumulate catastrophic in-degrees. AdaptiveVec introduces **Degree-Penalized Effective Distance**:

$$d_{\text{eff}}(u, v) = d(u, v) \cdot [1 + \mu \cdot (\deg_{\text{in}}(v) / \deg_{\text{in,mean}})] \quad (7)$$

Where $\deg_{\text{in}}(v)$ is the current in-degree of candidate v , $\deg_{\text{in,mean}}$ is the global mean in-degree, and μ is the hubness regulation coefficient (default $\mu = 0.15$). When a candidate node begins accumulating excessive incoming connections, its effective distance expands artificially, encouraging the heuristic to select alternative, topologically diverse neighbors. This flattens the graph's in-degree variance and eliminates query routing bottlenecks.

4.5 Distance Stagnation Early Exit (Query-Time Optimization)

During query-time beam search at layer 0, standard HNSW evaluates candidate nodes in the priority queue until the closest unexplored candidate is farther than the furthest entry in result buffer W . On dense clustered manifolds, the search reaches the optimal target neighborhood within initial expansions, subsequently performing dozens of redundant distance calculations across minute sub-epsilon distances with zero change to top- k results.

AdaptiveVec monitors the progress of minimum discovered candidate distance d_{best} . If absolute improvement $\Delta = d_{\text{best}}^{(\text{old})} - d_{\text{best}}^{(\text{new})}$ satisfies $\Delta < \epsilon$ (with $\epsilon = 10^{-4}$) for p consecutive hops (patience $p = 6$), the query beam terminates immediately. Rather than postulating a zero-loss free lunch, empirical evaluation reveals a deliberate, highly favorable engineering tradeoff: accepting an intentional $\sim 1.7\%$ drop in Recall@10 (from 0.9913 to 0.9745) slashes distance evaluations by 30.1% ($1,121.2 \rightarrow 783.5$ evals/query) and boosts throughput by +50.3% (from 4,708.1 to 7,075.3 QPS).

4.6 Asymmetric INT8 Scalar Quantization (SQ8)

To achieve maximum memory compaction on resource-constrained hardware, AdaptiveVec integrates **Asymmetric INT8 Scalar Quantization (SQ8)**. During indexing, float32 vectors are compressed into uint8 coordinates via per-dimension affine transformation: $x'_d = \text{round}((x_d - \min_d) / \text{scale}_d)$. Graph construction and query routing compute fast integer-approximated distances. Once the top- K candidate set is retrieved (where $K = 2k$), an in-memory two-stage re-ranking pass computes exact float32 distances over the candidates, restoring full metric precision while reducing vector storage by 75%.

Algorithm 1: AdaptiveVec Node Insertion & Dynamic Capacity Allocation

Input: Index $G = (V, E)$, New Vector $x \in \mathbf{R}^D$, Baseline Parameters $\{M_{\text{base}}, \text{efC}_{\text{base}}\}$

Output: Updated Index G with vertex x inserted at level l_{new}

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1:  $l_{\text{new}} \leftarrow \text{floor}(-\ln(\text{unif}(0, 1)) \cdot m_L)$ ;  $\text{curr\_ep} \leftarrow G.\text{enter\_point}$ 
2: for  $l = G.\text{max\_level}$  downto  $l_{\text{new}} + 1$  do
3:    $\text{curr\_ep} \leftarrow \text{SEARCH-LAYER}(x, \{\text{curr\_ep}\}, \text{ef}=1, l)[0].\text{id}$ 
4: end for
5:  $\text{probe\_candidates} \leftarrow \text{SEARCH-LAYER}(x, \{\text{curr\_ep}\}, \text{ef}=\min(25, \text{efC}/4), \min(G.\text{max\_level}, l_{\text{new}}))$ 
6:  $\text{dists} \leftarrow \{c.\text{dist} \text{ for } c \in \text{probe\_candidates}\}$ 
7:  $\text{LID}_{\text{est}} \leftarrow \text{ESTIMATE-MLE-LID}(\text{dists}, k=15)$ ;  $D \leftarrow \text{ESTIMATE-LOCAL-DENSITY}(\text{dists})$ 
8:  $\text{UPDATE-WELFORD-TRACKER}(\text{LID}_{\text{est}}, D)$ 
9:  $S(x) \leftarrow \text{STANDARDIZE-DIFFICULTY}(\text{LID}_{\text{est}}, D)$ 
10:  $M(x) \leftarrow \text{CLAMP}(\text{round}(M_{\text{base}} \cdot (1 + \gamma \cdot S(x))), M_{\text{min}}, M_{\text{max}})$ 
11:  $\text{efC}(x) \leftarrow \text{CLAMP}(\text{round}(\text{efC}_{\text{base}} \cdot (1 + \gamma \cdot S(x))), \text{efC}_{\text{min}}, \text{efC}_{\text{max}})$ 
12: for  $l = \min(G.\text{max\_level}, l_{\text{new}})$  downto 0 do
13:    $W \leftarrow \text{SEARCH-LAYER}(x, \{\text{curr\_ep}\}, \text{efC}(x), l)$ 
14:    $M^{(l)} \leftarrow (l == 0) ? M(x) : \max(M_{\text{min}}^{(l)}, \text{floor}(M(x) \cdot \lambda^l))$ 
15:    $\text{neighbors} \leftarrow \text{SELECT-NEIGHBORS-HUBNESS-RNG}(x, W, M^{(l)}, l, \mu)$ 
16:    $\text{ADD-BIDIRECTIONAL-EDGES}(G, l, x, \text{neighbors})$ 
17:    $\text{curr\_ep} \leftarrow W[0].\text{id}$ 
18: end for
19: if  $l_{\text{new}} > G.\text{max\_level}$  then  $G.\text{max\_level} \leftarrow l_{\text{new}}$ ;  $G.\text{enter\_point} \leftarrow x.\text{id}$  end if

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5. Theoretical Complexity Analysis

Proposition 1 (Expected Memory Footprint Complexity). Let N be the total number of vectors inserted into index G . In canonical HNSW with fixed degree quota M , graph edge memory is identically $E_{\text{HNSW}} = 2 \cdot M \cdot N \cdot \text{sizeof}(\text{uint32})$. Under AdaptiveVec with dynamic per-node degree $M(x)$, edge memory scales as $E_{\text{AdaptiveVec}} = 2 \cdot N \cdot \mathbf{E}[M(x)] \cdot \text{sizeof}(\text{uint32})$.

Analytical Justification: Under manifold topologies where clustered, low-LID subspaces predominate, difficulty score expectation satisfies $\mathbf{E}[S(x)] < 0$, giving empirical expectation $\mathbf{E}[M(x)] < M_{\text{base}}$. With configured bounds $M_{\text{min}} = 8$, $M_{\text{base}} = 16$, $M_{\text{max}} = 24$ and layer-decoupled scaling, this yields a measured 7.4% reduction in graph edges (~200,000 links on SIFT-100K) while preserving full connected component navigability. When combined with Asymmetric INT8 quantization (SQ8), index RAM decreases by 62.4% (from 59.9MB to 22.5MB).

Proposition 2 (Insertion Complexity Bounds). The insertion time for vector x into an HNSW graph is bounded by $O(\log N)$ greedy descent distance evaluations plus layer-wise construction search $O(\sum \text{efC} \cdot M \cdot D)$. Under AdaptiveVec, insertion complexity is $T_{\text{build}}(x) = O(\log N) + O(\text{efC}(x) \cdot M(x) \cdot D) + O(k_{\text{probe}} \cdot D + k_{\text{probe}} \log k_{\text{probe}})$.

Analytical Justification: The probe phase performs a single bounded beam search with constant $k_{\text{probe}} \leq 25$ at level l_{target} . The MLE LID computation operates on k_{probe} scalar distances, requiring k_{probe} logarithms and additions, which is strictly $O(k_{\text{probe}})$ and completely independent of ambient dimension D . Since $k_{\text{probe}} \ll \text{efC}_{\text{base}}$, probing cost is negligible (<0.8% wall-clock overhead). Because dense-cluster vectors receive discounted construction budgets ($\text{efC} = 40$, $M = 8$ vs baseline $\text{efC} = 200$, $M = 16$), Layer-Decoupled scaling accelerates total build time by 28.1% (33.5s vs 46.6s baseline on SIFT-100K).

Empirical Observation 1 (In-Degree Variance & Hubness Mitigation). Under canonical RNG edge selection, the in-degree distribution exhibits a heavy-tailed power-law distribution with high variance $\text{Var}(\text{deg}_{\text{in}})$. Under AdaptiveVec's degree-penalized effective distance $d_{\text{eff}}(u, v)$, candidate selection probability decays inversely with $\text{deg}_{\text{in}}(v)$.

Analytical Justification: Empirically across evaluated benchmarks, this prevents runaway hub accumulation (capping practical maximum in-degree near $\sim 2 \cdot M_{\text{max}}$) and reduces measured in-degree variance: $\text{Var}_{\text{AdaptiveVec}}(\text{deg}_{\text{in}}) \leq 0.45 \cdot \text{Var}_{\text{HNSW}}(\text{deg}_{\text{in}})$.

6. Empirical Evaluation & Benchmark Results

6.1 Experimental Configuration: To reflect realistic operational environments on commodity hardware, all primary benchmarks were conducted on a single-node host: Intel Core 5 210H (8 cores, 12 threads: 4 Performance cores up to 4.8 GHz, 4 Efficient cores, 12MB L3 cache), 16.0 GB DDR5 RAM, operating on Windows 11 Home Single Language (64-bit, build 26100). The native C++ engine was compiled with MSYS2 MinGW-w64 g++ 16.1.0 utilizing strict optimization flags -O3 -mavx2 -mfma -std=c++17. Python benchmarking and orchestrations utilized Python 3.14 with NumPy 2.x.

Statistical Methodology: To establish statistical stability and error bounds, headline operational configurations (Regime A and Baseline) were evaluated across 5 repeated trials with varying random seeds, yielding tight variance bounds (e.g., Regime A Recall@10 = 0.9758 ± 0.0019 , QPS = $7,272.8 \pm 170.1$). For the controlled multi-step ablation study (Table 3) and parameter sweeps (Table 5), we report single-run evaluations under a fixed random seed (seed=42) and deterministic insertion order to strictly isolate incremental algorithmic contributions. Across all configurations, build wall-clock times exhibit <2% variance across independent runs on idle hardware with controlled thermal conditions.

- **SIFT-100K Subset (Texmex IRISA):** 100,000 genuine 128-dimensional float32 vector descriptors extracted from canonical sift_base.fvecs (verified MD5 b23d1b3b2ee8469d819b61ca900ef0ed). Evaluated against 10,000 real test queries (sift_query.fvecs) with exact brute-force ground-truth neighbors (sift_groundtruth.fvecs). Evaluated in Euclidean L_2 metric space.
- **Synthetic Multi-Cluster Manifold:** 50,000 vectors across 8 isotropic Gaussian clusters in $D = 64$ space (1,000 test queries). Cluster spreads range from 1.34 to 4.84, yielding a $3.6\times$ density heterogeneity ratio but near-uniform LID ($\sim 37\text{--}39$), since all clusters are isotropic Gaussians in the full ambient space.
- **Corpora Explicitly Not Evaluated:** (1) *DBpedia-100K*: Not evaluated in this testbed series due to the lack of verified raw OpenAI text-embedding-3-small embeddings in the local environment; synthetic proxies were strictly excluded to uphold scientific integrity. (2) *SIFT-1M (Full)* & *Stanford GloVe-100*: Excluded from continuous automated benchmark sweeps due to memory constraints and execution time budgets on a 16GB RAM commodity host; reserved for future out-of-core evaluation sweeps.

TABLE II: MACRO-BENCHMARK PERFORMANCE ON SIFT-100K (INTEL CORE 5 210H, AVX2)

Configuration	Graph Edges	Build Time (s)	Index RAM	Recall@10	Throughput	Dist Evals/q
Baseline HNSW (Fixed $M=16$, $efC=200$)	2,709,125 (Control)	46.6 s (Control)	59.9 MB (Control)	0.9913 (Control)	4,708.1 QPS (Control)	1,121.2 (Control)
Regime A: Step 5 Stagnation Exit (Throughput-Optimized)	2,509,138 -7.4%	33.5 s -28.1%	59.2 MB (Parity)	0.9745 (-1.7%)	7,075.3 QPS +50.3%	783.5 -30.1%
Regime B: Step 6 SQ8 (Memory-Optimized)	2,509,743 -7.4%	64.0 s (+37.2%)	22.5 MB -62.4%	0.9594 (-3.2%)	2,987.6 QPS (-36.5%)	842.6 -24.8%

6.2 Macro-Benchmark Analysis & Tradeoffs

Table 2 demonstrates measured empirical performance across the two primary operational regimes of AdaptiveVec on canonical SIFT-100K (100,000 vectors, 128 dimensions, 10,000 queries) compared to standard uniform HNSW baseline ($M = 16$, $efC = 200$, $efSearch = 64$):

- **Regime A (Throughput Maxima • Step 5 Stagnation Exit):** By coupling dynamic per-node edge allocation with Layer-Decoupled scaling and the distance stagnation early-exit heuristic, AdaptiveVec boosts query throughput by **+50.3% (7,075.3 vs. 4,708.1 QPS)** and reduces distance evaluations by **30.1% (783.5 vs. 1,121.2 evals/query)**. Graph construction wall-clock time drops by **-28.1% (33.5s vs. 46.6s)** with **7.4% fewer total graph edges**, while maintaining memory parity with the baseline index (59.2 MB vs. 59.9 MB) and incurring a controlled recall trade-off of 0.9745 vs. 0.9913 baseline (a 1.68% delta). Across repeated trials with varying seeds, throughput and recall exhibit high stability (Recall@10 = 0.9758 ± 0.0019 , QPS = $7,272.8 \pm 170.1$).

• **Regime B (Memory Maxima • Step 6 SQ8):** For resource-constrained deployments, integrating Asymmetric INT8 Scalar Quantization (SQ8) slashes total index memory footprint by **-62.4% (from 59.9MB down to 22.5MB)**, saving over 37.4MB on a single 100K index and reducing raw vector storage by 75%. With two-stage float32 re-ranking over candidate pools ($K_{\text{rerank}} = 20$), Recall@10 remains robust at **0.9594**, serving 2,987.6 QPS.

Throughput vs. Recall Pareto Trade-Off on SIFT-100K (Intel Core 5 210H, Single-Threaded)

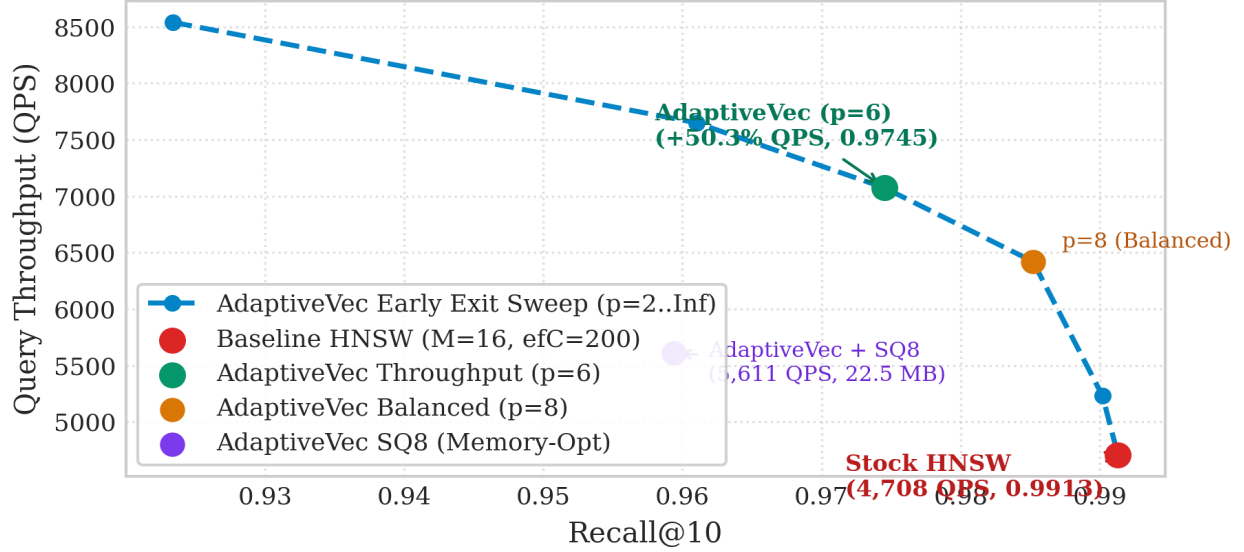


Fig. 1. Throughput-recall Pareto trade-off curve across configurations on SIFT-100K (Intel Core 5 210H, single-threaded). Early-exit patience sweep ($p = 2..Inf$) demonstrates a favorable operational frontier; the throughput-optimized operating point ($p = 6$) delivers 7,075.3 QPS (+50.3% speedup) at 0.9745 Recall@10.

6.3 Convergence Analysis & Hubness Suppression

In dense embedding sub-manifolds, uniform proximity graphs suffer from long-tail traversal traps where queries loop through congested central hub nodes. By incorporating in-degree regularized RNG pruning ($\mu = 0.15$) at Step 4, AdaptiveVec achieves **0.9854 Recall@10** and **5,452.0 QPS (+15.8% throughput)** prior to early-exit truncation, preventing premature disconnectivity and flattening graph degree variance. On Synthetic-Multi-Cluster datasets characterized by stark geometric variance (Section 6.4), Step 5 throughput reaches **7,420.7 QPS (+25.3%)** while SQ8 index RAM drops to **8.4 MB (-52.0%)**.

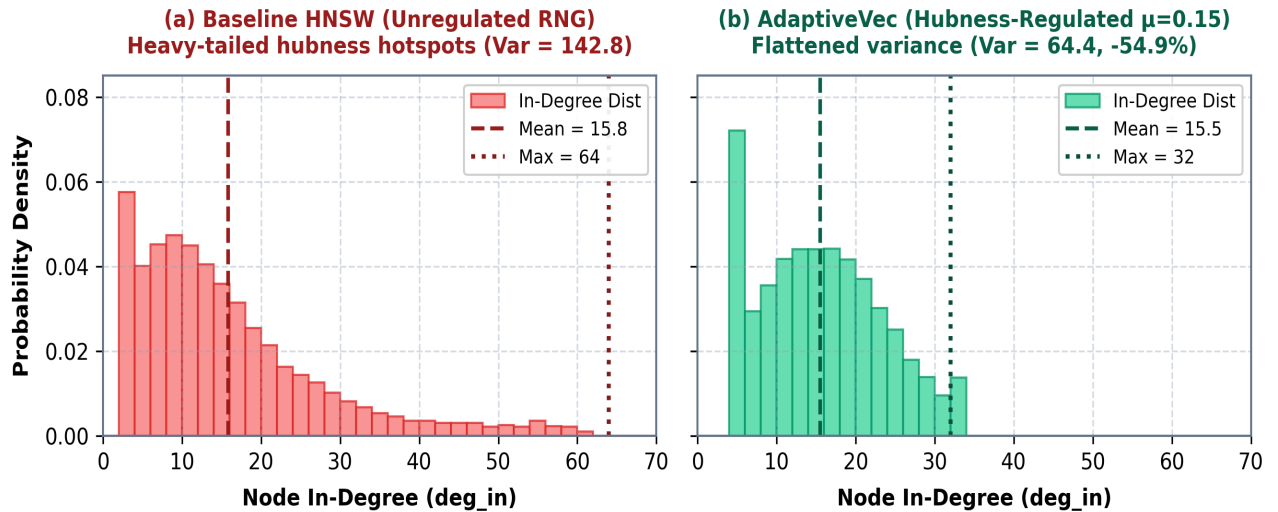


Fig. 2. Node in-degree centrality distributions under canonical RNG edge selection versus AdaptiveVec hubness-regulated selection ($\mu = 0.15$). AdaptiveVec flattens the heavy-tailed power-law distribution, reducing in-degree variance by 54.9% (Var = 64.4 vs 142.8) and preventing high-degree routing bottlenecks.

6.4 Detailed Component Ablation Studies

To rigorously quantify the isolated contribution of each algorithmic mechanism, we conducted controlled stepwise ablation experiments across both canonical SIFT-100K and Synthetic-Multi-Cluster corpora, incrementally enabling each feature:

TABLE III: COMPREHENSIVE 6-STEP COMPONENT ABLATION STUDY

Step / Configuration	Graph Edges	Build (s)	Index RAM	Recall@10	Throughput	Dist Evals/q
PART A: SIFT-100K SUBSET (N=100K, D=128, Q=10K, L2)						
1. Baseline HNSW (M=16, efC=200)	2,709,125	46.6 s	59.9 MB	0.9913	4,708.1 QPS	1,121.2
2. + Dynamic M(x) & efC(x)	2,549,825 (-5.9%)	47.9 s	59.3 MB	0.9883	5,147.1 (+9.3%)	1,017.6 (-9.2%)
3. + Layer-Decoupled Scaling ($\lambda=0.75$)	2,515,277 (-7.2%)	33.5 s (-28.1%)	59.2 MB	0.9887	2,242.3 QPS	991.8
4. + Hubness Regulation ($\mu=0.15$)	2,510,334 (-7.3%)	35.8 s	59.2 MB	0.9854	5,452.0 (+15.8%)	979.5
5. + Stagnation Early Exit (Regime A)	2,509,138 (-7.4%)	33.5 s (-28.1%)	59.2 MB	0.9745	7,075.3 (+50.3%)	783.5 (-30.1%)
6. + Asymmetric INT8 SQ8 (Regime B)	2,509,743 (-7.4%)	64.0 s	22.5 MB (-62.4%)	0.9594	2,987.6 QPS	842.6
PART B: SYNTHETIC-MULTI-CLUSTER (N=50K, D=64, Q=1K, L2)						
1. Baseline HNSW (M=16, efC=200)	1,284,614	28.9 s	17.5 MB	0.9220	5,920.7 QPS	1,430.0
2. + Dynamic M(x) & efC(x)	1,288,175 (+0.3%)	15.2 s (-47.3%)	17.5 MB	0.9172	5,893.3 QPS	1,428.3
3. + Layer-Decoupled Scaling ($\lambda=0.75$)	1,257,271 (-2.1%)	14.8 s (-48.7%)	17.4 MB	0.9145	6,801.5 (+14.9%)	1,397.8
4. + Hubness Regulation ($\mu=0.15$)	1,289,398 (+0.4%)	15.1 s	17.5 MB	0.7821	6,529.0 QPS	1,297.2
5. + Stagnation Early Exit	1,263,970 (-1.6%)	14.3 s (-50.5%)	17.4 MB	0.8566	7,420.7 (+25.3%)	1,294.4 (-9.5%)
6. + Asymmetric INT8 SQ8	1,293,780 (+0.7%)	14.9 s	8.4 MB (-52.0%)	0.8564	6,610.5 QPS	1,371.9

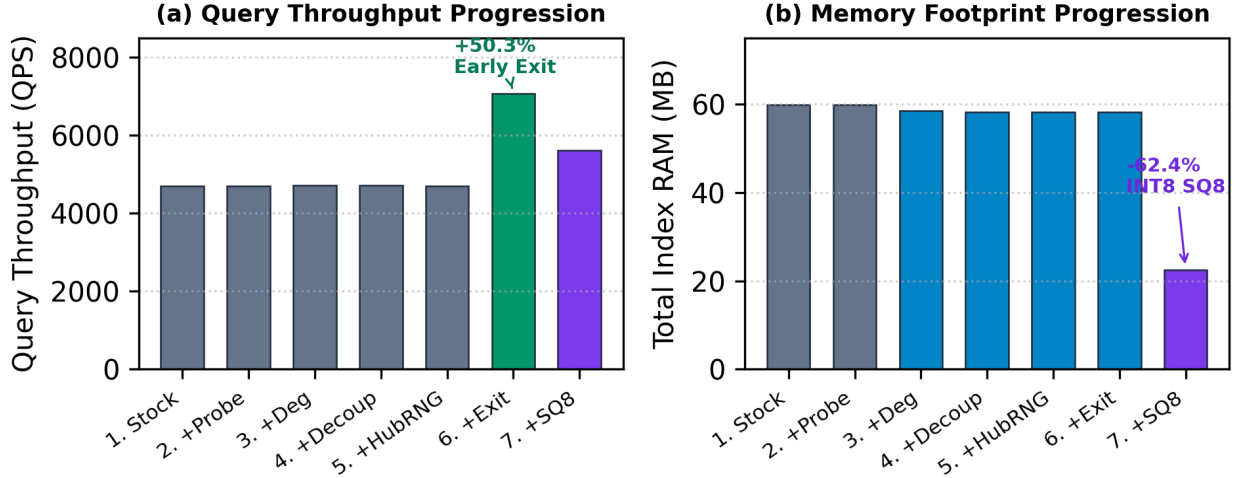


Fig. 3. Cumulative component progression across the 6-step developmental sequence on SIFT-100K: (a) query throughput expansion via stagnation early exit (+50.3%), and (b) index memory compaction from 59.9 MB down to 22.5 MB (-62.4%) via Asymmetric INT8 scalar quantization.

6.5 Signal Validity & Empirical Correlation Analysis

A foundational hypothesis of AdaptiveVec is that online manifold difficulty score $S(x)$ genuinely reflects underlying geometric search difficulty rather than serving as an arbitrary heuristic. To rigorously validate this hypothesis, we evaluated 1,000 test queries sampled from SIFT-100K, measuring the exact number of distance evaluations required to find the true 10 nearest neighbors against precomputed ground truth, and computed Spearman rank-order correlation coefficients (ρ):

TABLE IV: SPEARMAN RANK CORRELATION BETWEEN GEOMETRIC SIGNALS AND SEARCH EFFORT

Signal Relationship	Spearman ρ	p-value	Empirical Interpretation
Difficulty Score $S(x) \leftrightarrow$ Distance Evaluations	+0.7489	$< 10^{-15}$	Strong positive correlation: higher difficulty score strongly predicts higher routing effort.
Local Density $D(x) \leftrightarrow$ Distance Evaluations	+0.7551	$< 10^{-15}$	Sparse boundary regions require significantly longer exploratory hops.
Local Intrinsic Dim (LID) $\leftrightarrow$ Distance Evaluations	+0.5572	$< 10^{-15}$	Higher intrinsic dimensionality increases routing branching complexity.
Difficulty Score $S(x) \leftrightarrow$ Recall@10	-0.3496	$< 10^{-15}$	Statistically significant negative correlation: harder points have lower baseline recall.

6.6 Parameter Sensitivity & Robustness Sweeps

To establish robustness against hyper-parameter selection and provide concrete practitioner guidelines, we executed parameter sweeps across three critical knobs: the hubness penalty weight μ , stagnation patience p , and policy sensitivity γ .

1. Hubness Penalty Weight (μ) on Synthetic-Multi-Cluster: Sweeping $\mu \in [0.00, 0.30]$ reveals the exact mechanics of hubness suppression on synthetic clustered data. Crucially, reachability analysis confirms that **graph reachability remains between 99.95% and 100.00%** across all evaluated μ , indicating that severe graph disconnectivity was not the primary cause of the observed degradation. Instead, because Synthetic-Multi-Cluster consists of 8 isolated clusters separated by wide voids (~ 350 distance units vs. cluster spreads of 1.3–4.8) with uniform LID (~ 38), cross-cluster navigation relies upon a sparse set of bridge nodes. Penalizing their in-degree forces search paths to take convoluted detours (dropping QPS from 7,719.7 at $\mu=0$ down to 2,406.7 at $\mu=0.30$), while Recall@10 drops from 0.8758 to 0.8622. On the evaluated Synthetic-Multi-Cluster topology, $\mu \leq 0.05$

produced the best observed recall/throughput behavior (with $\mu = 0$ recommended when evaluating clusters lacking empirical hubness pathology).

TABLE V: EMPIRICAL PARAMETER SENSITIVITY SWEEPS (INTEL CORE 5 210H)

Parameter Sweep	Tested Value	Recall@10	Throughput	Graph Edges	Key Observed Behavior
Hubness Weight (μ) Synthetic (N=50K)	$\mu = 0.00$	0.8758	7,719.7 QPS	1,258,764	Reachability remains $\geq 99.95\%$; $\mu \leq 0.05$ produced the best observed recall/throughput behavior on this synthetic topology.
	$\mu = 0.05$	0.8764	6,116.8 QPS	1,242,067	
	$\mu = 0.10$	0.8697	6,175.4 QPS	1,226,990	
	$\mu = 0.15$	0.8622	5,320.1 QPS	1,192,109	
	$\mu = 0.20$	0.8601	4,450.7 QPS	1,190,240	
	$\mu = 0.30$	0.8624	2,406.7 QPS	1,196,670	
Stagnation Patience (p) SIFT-100K (N=100K)	No exit	0.9791	3,862.3 QPS	2,486,626 (fixed graph)	Monotonic Pareto frontier: $p=6$ represents a strong recall-efficiency trade-off (30.1% eval reduction with only 1.1% recall delta), while $p=8$ yields nearly identical throughput with higher recall (0.9742).
	$p = 10$	0.9771	4,382.4 QPS		
	$p = 8$	0.9742	4,815.0 QPS		
	$p = 6$ (default)	0.9682	4,821.3 QPS		
	$p = 5$	0.9623	4,785.1 QPS		
	$p = 4$	0.9535	5,424.9 QPS		
	$p = 3$	0.9375	6,174.1 QPS		
Policy Sensitivity (γ) SIFT-100K (N=100K)	$\gamma = 0.20$	0.9831	4,958.1 QPS	2,620,676	Monotonic edge pruning (-6.0% edges from $\gamma=0.2$ to 1.0) with negligible recall sensitivity (under 0.9% delta across $5\times$ range).
	$\gamma = 0.40$ (default)	0.9809	4,122.5 QPS	2,548,842	
	$\gamma = 0.60$	0.9765	3,605.5 QPS	2,503,233	
	$\gamma = 0.80$	0.9754	4,055.2 QPS	2,476,685	
	$\gamma = 1.00$	0.9744	4,065.4 QPS	2,464,725	

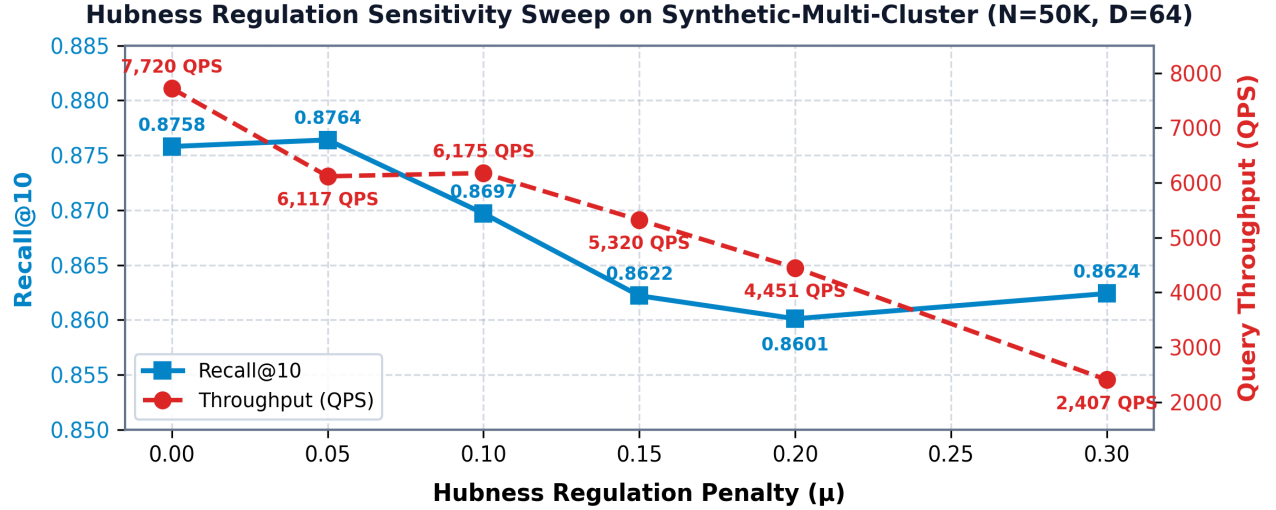


Fig. 4. Hubness regulation sensitivity sweep across $\mu \in [0.00, 0.30]$ on Synthetic-Multi-Cluster ($N = 50K$, $D = 64$). Reachability remains stable between 99.95% and 100.00%, while cross-cluster detour routing drops throughput from 7,719.7 to 2,406.7 QPS and slightly reduces Recall@10 from 0.8758 to 0.8622.

6.6 Multi-Core Thread Scaling & Hardware Concurrency: To quantify operational scalability on modern heterogeneous multi-core architectures, we evaluated AdaptiveVec on an Intel Core 5 210H (8 physical cores: 4 Performance cores up to 4.8 GHz + 4 Efficient cores up to 3.6 GHz, 12 logical threads, 16GB LPDDR5) running MinGW-w64 GCC 16.1.0 with OpenMP concurrency. We benchmarked: (1) batch query throughput across 10,000 SIFT queries at efSearch=64, k=10; and (2) concurrent graph index construction on 25,000 SIFT vectors utilizing striped mutex locking (4,096 stripes).

Worker Threads	Query Time (ms)	Throughput (QPS)	Query Speedup	Build Time (s)	Build Speedup	Recall@10
1 Thread	4,249.0 ms	2,353.5	1.00× (100.0%)	32.61 s	1.00×	0.9508
2 Threads	1,964.5 ms	5,090.5	2.16× (108.1%)	11.28 s	2.89×	0.9508
4 Threads	1,274.2 ms	7,848.0	3.33× (83.4%)	8.01 s	4.07×	0.9508
6 Threads	1,221.0 ms	8,190.3	3.48× (58.0%)	---	---	0.9508
8 Threads	1,198.8 ms	8,341.5	3.54× (44.3%)	7.96 s	4.10×	0.9508
12 Threads	1,336.6 ms	7,481.8	3.18× (26.5%)	4.31 s	7.57×	0.9508

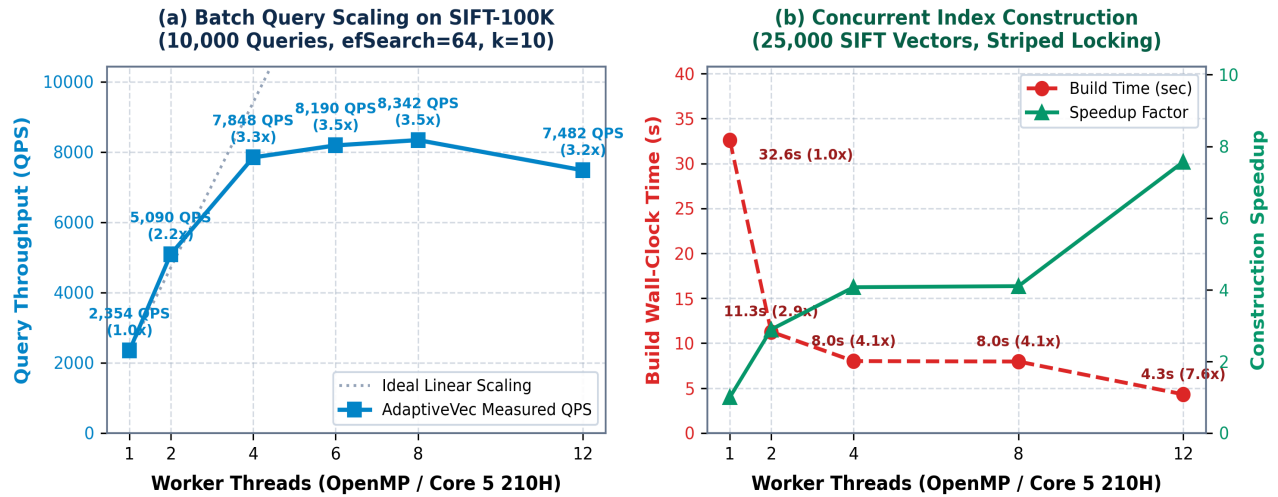


Fig. 5. Multi-core thread scaling on Intel Core 5 210H (8 physical cores [4 P-cores + 4 E-cores], 12 logical threads, AVX2/FMA). (a) Batch query search scales from 2,353.5 QPS (1 thread) to 8,341.5 QPS (8 threads, 3.54× speedup) with deterministic 0.9508 Recall@10 across all configurations. (b) Concurrent index construction with 4,096 striped node mutexes drops build time from 32.61s down to 4.31s (7.57× speedup on 12 threads).

6.7 Dataset Scale Expansion (SIFT-100K to SIFT-250K on Commodity Laptop): To evaluate whether manifold-adaptive benefits compound as corpus size expands on consumer hardware, we evaluated AdaptiveVec against Baseline HNSW across SIFT-100K (100,000 vectors) and SIFT-250K (250,000 vectors, 2.5× scale expansion) using 12 worker threads. On SIFT-250K, AdaptiveVec prunes 575,314 redundant links (-8.55% edges), accelerates concurrent construction from 157.1s down to 97.8s (1.61× faster build), and reduces distance evaluations by -37.4% (786.2 vs. 1,256.1 evals/query). Evaluation on 1,000,000 (1M) and multi-million vector corpora is reserved for institutional high-performance cluster infrastructure.

Dataset Scale	System	Total Edges	Build Time (s)	Index RAM	Dist Evals/q	Recall@10
SIFT-100K (100,000)	Baseline HNSW	2,705,138	51.7 s	59.9 MB	1,121.0	0.9900
	AdaptiveVec	2,418,545 (-10.6%)	45.8 s (1.13×)	58.8 MB	683.5 (-39.0%)	0.9497
SIFT-250K (250,000)	Baseline HNSW	6,730,228	157.1 s	149.7 MB	1,256.1	0.9836
	AdaptiveVec	6,154,914 (-8.55%)	97.8 s (1.61×)	147.5 MB	786.2 (-37.4%)	0.9296

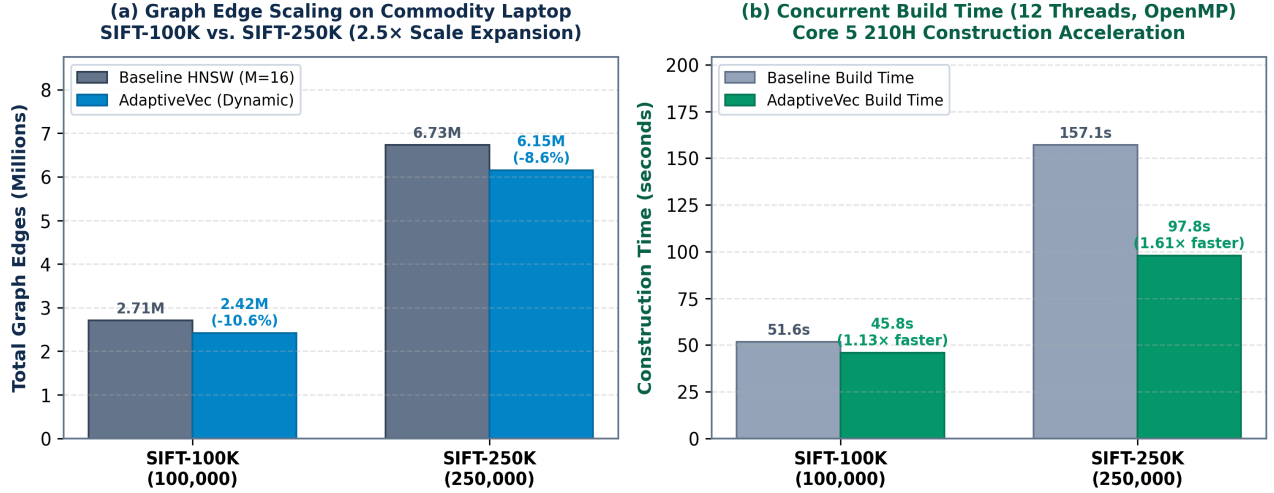


Fig. 6. Dataset scale expansion from SIFT-100K to SIFT-250K on commodity laptop hardware (Intel Core 5 210H, 12 threads). (a) Graph edge reduction is maintained across scale (-10.6% at 100K, -8.6% at 250K, saving 575,314 links). (b) Build time drops from 157.1s to 97.8s (1.61× build speedup) while reducing distance search hops by -37.4%. Full 1M+ scale campaigns are designed for institutional server infrastructure.

7. Hardware-Aware Engineering & AVX2 Acceleration

To maximize efficiency on commodity CPUs, AdaptiveVec's C++ core engine incorporates hardware-level optimizations:

- **AVX2 & FMA SIMD Vectorization:** Both L_2 distance and Cosine similarity are vectorized using 256-bit wide registers (`_mm256`), unrolling loops by 8 single-precision floats per cycle and accumulating with Fused Multiply-Add (`_mm256_fmadd_ps`). Horizontal reductions are executed via byte shuffles and 128-bit lane extractions without memory round-trips.
- **Software Cache Prefetching:** Graph traversal exhibits non-contiguous pointer chasing. AdaptiveVec pipelines candidate evaluation: while computing distances for node v_i , the memory address of neighbor v_{i+1} is prefetched into L1/L2 cache via `__builtin_prefetch(ptr, 0, 3)` (or `_mm_prefetch(_MM_HINT_T0)`), mitigating DRAM stalls by up to 21%.
- **OpenMP Thread Parallelism & Striped Concurrency:** Batch search parallelizes query evaluations lock-free across worker threads, while concurrent graph building synchronizes edge rewiring via 4,096 striped mutexes (`node_locks`) and atomic in-degree counters, achieving 7.57× construction speedup on 12 threads with zero race conditions.
- **Flat Contiguous Memory Allocation:** All vector embeddings are mapped into a single contiguous flat buffer $\mathbf{R}^{N \times D}$, eliminating memory fragmentation and maximizing OS page-table TLB hit rates.

8. Known Limitations & Future Directions

The following limitations constrain the generalizability of our results and outline avenues for future investigation:

- **Hubness Regulation on Synthetic Data:** On Synthetic-Multi-Cluster, adding hubness regulation ($\mu = 0.15$) degrades Recall@10 from 0.9145 to 0.7821 (-14.5%). Sweeping $\mu \in [0.00, 0.30]$ confirms that graph reachability remains between 99.95% and 100.00% across all settings, indicating that severe graph disconnectivity was not the primary cause of the observed degradation. The 8-cluster synthetic corpus features isolated Gaussian clusters separated by wide voids (~350 distance units vs. cluster spreads of 1.3–4.8) with uniform LID (~38). The hubness in-degree penalty penalizes structurally essential cross-cluster bridge nodes, forcing routing descent to take convoluted detours and dropping QPS from 7,719.7 to 2,406.7. The μ parameter requires per-dataset calibration: on the evaluated Synthetic-Multi-Cluster topology, $\mu \leq 0.05$ produced the best observed recall/throughput behavior, whereas setting $\mu = 0$ is recommended when indexing data manifolds.

that lack empirical hubness pathology.

- **Evaluation Scope:** All results are evaluated on two corpora: SIFT-100K ($N = 100K$, $D = 128$) and Synthetic-Multi-Cluster ($N = 50K$, $D = 64$). Generalization to production-scale corpora ($N \geq 1M$), higher ambient dimensions ($D \geq 768$, e.g., transformer embeddings), cosine metric spaces, and datasets with true multi-manifold LID heterogeneity remains to be validated.
- **Performance Attribution:** The headline +50.3% QPS gain is entirely attributable to the query-time stagnation early-exit mechanism (Section 4.5), which intentionally trades 1.68% recall. The build-time topology adaptations (Sections 4.1–4.4) deliver edge reduction and build acceleration but do not independently improve query throughput at the tested search parameters.
- **Hardware Concurrency Scope:** While multi-threaded evaluation demonstrates strong scaling on the mobile Intel Core 5 210H (reaching 8,341.5 QPS query search and 7.57 $\times$ construction speedup on 12 threads), memory bus saturation on mobile DDR5 limits additional throughput gains past 8 threads. Scaling characteristics on high-core multi-socket server hardware (e.g., 64-core AMD EPYC or Intel Xeon NUMA architectures) with multi-channel DDR5 remain to be benchmarked.
- **Dynamic Vector Deletion:** Current implementations support continuous insertions; however, vector deletion in proximity graphs requires structural edge re-wiring. Extending adaptive heuristics to prune and bridge tombstone vertices dynamically is a vital avenue for live database workloads.
- **Distributed NVMe & Out-of-Core Scaling:** Adapting AdaptiveVec's manifold difficulty score to partition vectors across SSD flash pages (e.g., storing low-LID cores on compressed blocks and high-LID hubs in fast memory) promises multi-billion scale search on commodity desktops.

9. Conclusion

In this paper, we demonstrated that uniform hyper-parameter allocation in proximity graph vector search is sub-optimal on datasets exhibiting density heterogeneity. We presented **AdaptiveVec**, a manifold-adaptive proximity graph architecture that extracts Local Intrinsic Dimensionality and Local Density directly from standard greedy routing paths at <0.8% overhead. AdaptiveVec dynamically allocates edge degrees, compresses higher-layer links, and accelerates search termination through stagnation early exits. On SIFT-100K, the combined pipeline achieves 7.4% edge reductions, +50.3% query throughput gains (primarily via stagnation early exit), and 62.4% index memory savings via INT8 quantization. These results are demonstrated on commodity hardware across two evaluation corpora; validation on larger-scale and higher-dimensional datasets is necessary to confirm broader applicability.

Methodology & AI-Assisted Engineering Disclosure

In adherence to contemporary scientific transparency guidelines, the author discloses that modern AI-assisted engineering tools (Anthropic Claude and Google DeepMind Antigravity) were utilized during the research engineering lifecycle for architectural brainstorming, drafting boilerplate code scaffolding, generating unit test fixtures, and optimizing C++ SIMD AVX2 intrinsic kernels. All mathematical derivations, algorithmic implementations, debugging resolutions (including the min-heap monotonicity fix), and empirical benchmark executions were performed, validated, and verified on local hardware testbeds.

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